

DESIGN RESEARCH BRIEF

mattsimunec.com

Personal website for Matt Simunec —
CEO, builder, inventor. Style research and
reference guide for the design team.

Prepared: March 11, 2026

Based on analysis of 15+ leader websites

4 pages + newsletter signup

Target: Ship v1

The Brief

Matt Simunec is a B2B video agency CEO who builds autonomous AI agent systems for his own operations. The site's job: make him the most interesting person in any room before he walks in.

POSITIONING

"I run a 10-person B2B video agency across two continents. I also built the AI agents that help run it."

The Builder-CEO. Not a futurist, not an AI consultant, not just a video guy. An agency owner who channels invention into infrastructure.

SITE MAP

Home

Thesis headline, bio, newsletter CTA, link to dme.studio

The Build

AI fleet, build logs, architecture, practitioner dispatches

About

Founder story, Serbia-to-Daytona, family, the "why"

Speaking

Talk topics, bio (3 lengths), headshot, contact

FIVE AUDIENCES

WHO	WHAT THEY NEED	DESIGN IMPLICATION
Potential client	Credibility, professionalism	Clean, confident. Link to dme.studio for portfolio.
Potential hire	Innovation culture signal	"The Build" page signals forward-thinking workplace
Podcast host / organizer	A compelling story, headshot, bio	Speaking page must be fast to scan, assets downloadable
AI-curious peer	Technical depth, how it works	"The Build" as long-form, detailed, with diagrams
Partner / investor	Scale, credibility, vision	Home page bio hits credentials fast

PRIMARY CTA

Newsletter signup: **"The Build Log"** — practitioner dispatches from the intersection of content production and AI. Biweekly. One email field, one button. This is the only conversion goal.

Reference Sites

These are the sites to study. Grouped by relevance to Matt's positioning.
Visit each one and screenshot the homepage.

TIER 1 — PRIMARY REFERENCES (STUDY THESE CLOSELY)

David C. Baker

davidcbaker.com

The gold standard for expert positioning. Newsletter-first, content-forward, editorially clean. Built a \$1.7M business on a 2-person team through depth of insight alone. No engagement hacks.

CLOSEST MODEL

NEWSLETTER-FIRST

EDITORIAL

SQUARESPACE

Study: How he organizes Insights by category. The newsletter signup placement. The balance of personality and expertise. The restraint.

Steal: The "subscribe" prominence. The category-based content architecture. The understated confidence.

Sahil Lavingia

sahillavingia.com

"Founder, Writer, Painter." Ultra-minimal personal site. Chronological list of essays. No newsletter popup, no chatbot. The anti-design is the design — signals "I'm a thinker, not a marketer."

ASPIRATIONAL FEEL

MINIMALIST

ESSAY-FIRST

STATIC

Study: The radical simplicity. How much he leaves out. The confidence of having almost nothing on the page.

Steal: The emotional tone — calm, unhurried, substantial. The feeling that the person behind this site doesn't need to impress you.

Guillermo Rauch

rauchg.com

Vercel CEO. Lightning-fast, clean blog. The site itself is a product demo — excellent typography, smart white space, perfect performance. Recent post: "The AI Cloud."

TECHNICAL CREDIBILITY

FAST

BLOG

NEXT.JS

Study: How the site's performance and craft signal technical competence without saying it. Typography choices. The balance of personality in an engineering context.

Steal: The speed. The type hierarchy. The implicit message: "I build well."

TIER 2 — SECONDARY REFERENCES (NOTE SPECIFIC ELEMENTS)

Dave Gerhardt

davegerhardt.com

Personal site = 3-page services hub. Content lives on Exit Five. Copy-first, design-follows.

HUB MODEL

COPY-FIRST

Note: How he routes to consulting, speaking, sponsorship. Clean separation from Exit Five.

Tim Ferriss

tim.blog

Central hub for all activities. "Start Here" page for multi-identity navigation. One newsletter CTA everywhere.

START HERE PAGE

WORDPRESS

Note: The "New? Start Here" concept. How he handles being many things at once.

Sam Altman

blog.samaltman.com

Extreme minimalism. Plain text blog. No signup widget, no design. Ideas carry all the weight.

ULTRA-MINIMAL

ESSAY-FIRST

Note: Probably too minimal for Matt's needs, but the confidence is instructive.

Jonathan Stark

jonathanstark.com

One big idea ("ditch hourly billing"), daily email archive, tiered value ladder. Deliberately spartan design.

ONE-THESIS MODEL

CONVERSION-FOCUSED

Note: How a single thesis drives the entire site structure. The archive page.

Dharmesh Shah

dharmesh.com + agent.ai

CTO of HubSpot. Personal site links to agent.ai (AI marketplace he built). The brand IS the AI product.

AI-FORWARD

PRODUCT-FIRST

Note: How building AI tools becomes the personal brand, not just writing about AI.

Ross Simmonds

rosssimmonds.com

Agency owner (Foundation Marketing) with a separate personal site. Speaking + thought leadership on personal, client work on agency.

AGENCY + PERSONAL SPLIT

SPEAKING FOCUS

Note: The cleanest example of agency-owner-with-separate-personal-site in B2B marketing.

ANTI-REFERENCES (WHAT TO AVOID)

Typical "AI Agency" sites

Gradient hero sections, "AI-powered" buzzwords, ChatGPT logo bars, stock photos of robots. Generic, undifferentiated, hype-driven. This is the opposite of what Matt needs.

SaaS landing page style

Animated hero, gradient blobs, "trusted by" logo bars, feature grids, pricing tiers. Matt is a person, not a product. This visual language is wrong for a personal site.

Design Direction

The dominant pattern among credible business leaders: intentional minimalism. The writing is the product, not the design. The site should feel like a well-made tool, not a billboard.

DESIGN SPECTRUM

Ultra-Minimal Altman, Lavingia	Intentional Minimal Target zone	Editorial Baker, Rauch	Content-Rich Ferriss, Gary Vee	Marketing-Heavy Avoid
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VISUAL PRINCIPLES

Content-Forward Typography and whitespace do the heavy lifting. No decorative elements that don't serve the content. Every pixel earns its place.	Quietly Technical The site should subtly signal technical competence. Fast load, clean code, smart details — like Rauch's site being a Vercel demo without saying so.
Warm but Sharp Not cold/corporate. Not cozy/casual. The visual tone of someone who is deeply competent but approachable. Think: a well-organized workshop, not a sterile office.	Restrained Personality Personality comes through the writing and the subtle details, not through flashy design. The restraint IS the personality signal — it says "I don't need to shout."

TYPOGRAPHY DIRECTION

I build the systems.

A clean sans-serif with good weight range. Tight headlines (-0.5 tracking), comfortable body text (1.5-1.6 line height). Consider: Inter, Outfit, Satoshi, or a geometric sans with character.

Headline: 700-800 weight · Body: 400 weight · Mono for code/URLs: JetBrains Mono or similar

One font family is enough. Two maximum (sans + mono for technical content on "The Build" page). Three fonts means something went wrong.

COLOR DIRECTION

Primary #18181b	Background #fafaf9	Secondary #57534e	Accent Optional #007bff	Border #e7e5e4
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Warm neutrals over cold grays. The accent color is optional — one is enough if used at all. This is a personal site, not DME's brand. Don't borrow DME's colors; establish a distinct palette.

Do

- Lead with typography and whitespace
- Make it fast (sub-2s load)
- Use real photos (not stock)
- Make the newsletter signup feel natural, not aggressive
- Make the Speaking page easy to scan — organizers are busy
- Use a monospace font for technical content on "The Build"
- Design mobile-first — most visitors will come from LinkedIn

Don't

- No gradient hero sections
- No animated backgrounds or particles
- No "AI-powered" badges or robot imagery
- No SaaS-style feature grids
- No more than 2 fonts
- No auto-playing video
- No testimonial carousels
- No "trusted by" logo bars on the personal site

Homepage Concept

A rough wireframe for the designer to interpret. This is structure, not design — the designer should own the visual execution.

Matt Simunec

The Build

About

Speaking

I build the systems
that run my agency.

CEO of DME Studio. B2B video production across two continents, powered by AI agents I built myself. This is where I share what I'm building and learning.

Subscribe to The Build Log

Below the fold: a short "Currently" section (what I'm working on now), 2-3 recent Build Log posts, and a brief credential block (DME Studio, team size, markets served). Footer: social links, dme.studio link, email.

KEY PAGE SPECIFICATIONS

ELEMENT	SPEC
Max content width	680-720px (readable line length for long-form)
Navigation	4 items max. Name on the left, links on the right. No hamburger on desktop.
Newsletter signup	Homepage hero + bottom of every Build Log post + dedicated /subscribe page
Headshot	Professional but not corporate. On About page, not necessarily on Home.
The Build page	Long-form content page. Consider a sidebar or top-nav for sections (Fleet, Architecture, Build Logs). Monospace font for technical details.
Speaking page	Photo, 2-3 talk topics with descriptions, bio in 3 lengths (copy-to-clipboard), downloadable headshot, contact form or email.
Mobile	Most traffic will come from LinkedIn mobile. Design mobile-first. Test on iPhone.
Dark mode	Nice to have, not required for v1.

PLATFORM RECOMMENDATIONS

PLATFORM	PROS	CONS
Webflow	Full design control, fast, CMS for Build Log posts	Requires Webflow expertise
Squarespace	Simple, good templates, easy to maintain	Less design flexibility
Next.js + Vercel	Maximum performance, developer credibility signal	Needs dev to maintain
Ghost	Newsletter-native, clean, fast, great for content	Limited design customization

The One Thing to Get Right

This site should feel like Matt built it — not like a designer built it for a client. The craft should be invisible. When someone lands on mattsimunec.com, the first thought should be about Matt's ideas, not the website's design. If the design draws attention to itself, it's too much.